

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

ASE_Benin_2022-23_3-month report_(2)

Fellowship Organization

African School of Economics (ASE)

Fellowship City

Abomey-Calavi

Fellowship Country

Benin

Fellowship Start Date

07/04/2022

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

07/04/2023

What is your fellowship title/role?

Project Coordinator and Communications Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

- Plan and implement communication strategy
- co-manage social media accounts (Facebook and Twitter)
- Create marketing content such as articles and visual media (videography, photography)
- edit video footage
- Plan events
- Conduct field marketing through flyer distribution and cold calls
- Assist with courses on Academic English through role as a TA

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Neutral

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Somewhat

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

There was no formal onboarding process. After arriving, there was a day when I asked questions and was told to research our social media pages. I was also taught the proper format to write articles for the news section on our website. Besides this, there was no other onboarding. This was handled by my former supervisor, who no longer works at ASE as of around October 1, 2022.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?**Describe a representative day at work.**

There is no representative day. After my supervisor unexpectedly left, I set my own hours and usually began work around 10:30 AM and end around 8 PM. I start the day by answering our Facebook page's direct messages, then work on creating content for social media. This entails editing video footage, writing articles, and taking pictures of students. I post on social media around 11 AM and around 3 or 4 PM.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

started the Day in the Life video series
-helped increase communication between Lagos, Abidjan, and Cotonou campuses of ASE

What is your organization's work culture like?**What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.**

We have around 20 full time staff members in our three story administrative building. I work in communication, and as of now, I am the only person in the department. We also have admissions, accounting, logistics, international affairs, office of the dean(undergrad), office of the dean(postgrad), human resources, and IT. In addition, we have 4 research institutes and each of these has a small office space with a director and a few doctoral student researchers.

To whom do you report?

Since early October, I do not have a direct supervisor since my original supervisor left unexpectedly to study in France. Also, the consultant who was working with us, also left because his contract was not renewed. In the meantime, I do report to the Director of Academic Affairs as well as The Dean of graduate students. I talk to them, to coordinate admissions, communication materials, and events. However, they are not consistently responsive / available.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

No

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

He impromptu left to France. I would like to talk to my new supervisor when they come

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

- increase social media visibility of ASE through creating quality visual content
- maintain video series that highlights daily life of students and the value of an ASE education
- create a cohesive communication strategy across all ASE campuses

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Never

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

No, but it has been discussed

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Neutral

Please briefly explain your response.

At the beginning, I definitely felt prepared for my responsibilities because I had experience creating content, writing, and marketing strategy. After my supervisor left, I felt and still feel that I am having to over reach and fill a large void by not having any guidance on communication strategy and priorities.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I purchased a one way ticket online through the United website and flew on United Airlines from Austin, TX to Washington D.C, then to Brussels vis Brussels airlines. At Brussels, I flew on Brussels Airlines direct to Cotonou, Benin. The trip cost 1101.00 USD. I have not yet booked a return flight.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

90 day long stay visa

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

Renewing it every 90 days at the Beninese Consulate

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

Before heading to my host country, I applied for and received an e-visa.

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

I believe it was 90 USD

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

We paid the visa amounts

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

If yes, please explain further

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

It would be helpful if ASE at least informed us what the visa process was like. No one knew anything when I was trying to apply for a visa in the US. Also, sponsoring a year long work visa potentially

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

Yellow Fever, Polio. Insurance covered these

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

My arrival felt fine and exciting. Staff at ASE welcomed me warmly and helped me settle in. We had all the necessities at home. A more formal onboarding process for work, which includes transferring knowledge from the previous fellow, could be helpful.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Yes provided for and paid by organization. We live on the 4th floor of our administration building.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Somewhat Urban (Suburban)

Please describe your living environment

we live in mixed residential/small business neighborhood in Abomey-Calavi that feels very suburban. It is in the metro area of Cotonou, but the pace of life is slower than the city. 15 minutes away by car, it can feel rural.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

I walk down two sets of stairs. It takes 35 seconds door to door and costs about zero dollars.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

n/a

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

There is rainy/dry season. The rainy season starts in April or May and lasts until July. There is small break in July/August, then it becomes rainy again in September-November. Dry season is December-April or May. We are currently at the end of the rainy season.

Temperatures are warm but never too hot.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

Work clothing can be Western clothes (pants and button up) or traditional fabric (pagne). In the host community, many people wear traditional fabric (especially for parties and ceremonies), but also a significant amount wear Western clothing as well.

How have you been spending your free time?

Working out, playing soccer, calling friends/family back home. Working out, playing soccer, calling friends/family back home. Because there are students here, I often chat with students in the halls.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

It is hard but I make an effort to call family every week and close friends at least once a month. My social life here is not too big, but I try to get out at least two times a week to either play sports or meet friends outside of the home.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

Yes. There does not seem to be much crime at all. I am sure there is petty theft here and there but that is it.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

Knowing where I am going and letting roommate know my location; securing my wallet ; avoiding streets at night

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

none

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

There does not seem to be much crime in Cotonou in general. Locals also tell me this. But being a man I am less concerned

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

In terms of improving my French ability, I think I have made slight progress. I did not realize the challenge of practicing a language in a university setting with lots of English speakers. I am also learning the inner workings of a private Pan-African university, and I think I have started to acquire knowledge how communication systems work as well. I am indeed working towards my goal of creating engaging creative content, albeit it is a slow process.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

My living arrangements are great most of the time. Sometimes the water shuts off for no reason. Sometimes student- acquaintances wander up to say hello (which is nice) but enter at awkward times. More importantly, I am frustrated at work because my supervisor left without any explanation until a month later, not giving me any advice or guidance on what to do. I feel like I have fallen in between the cracks yet there is still a lot of communications work to be done. Outside of work is great.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

Guidance on how to lead the strategy on marketing

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I did not experience culture shock like I thought I would. Sometimes i just feel more tired than usual, whether is it because of the climate or because I am forced to be more social here, which is taxing. I really try to observe how people act and figure out why they act this way. I also make sure to stay grounded and exercise so I feel less stressed. I think staying connected back home to some degree is also crucial.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

How quickly things turn normal. A lot of things are more similar than they are different.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

Feeling more fatigued than usual. Really wanting to do a good job while also acutely aware of the privilege I have of being in Africa. Balancing enriching my life with personal experiences while also focusing on work, and my well being, while still connecting with friends/family/former clients back home.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

Freedom of having own car.
-more variety of healthy foods (fruits, veggies, superfoods etc)
consistent wifi everywhere I go
Blueberries and Eggo Waffles

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

Feeling connected to nearby community
Feeling actively engaged in new experiences
Meeting more people

How is your stipend being paid?

monthly direct deposit in U.S. dollars

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Wire

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

no

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$38.00	\$0.00	\$10.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$67.00	\$10.00	\$10.00	\$175.00	\$5.00	\$60.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$5.00	\$0.00	\$65.00	\$15.00	\$10.00	395.00
Specify "Other"					
clothes					

Final Thoughts

PiAf's orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

I was nervous entering the orientation, but by the end I felt like I had established myself as part of the community. I think the sessions on identity and break out groups were the most helpful. Overall, I think the most helpful thing was bonding with other people going through a similar experience.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

no

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

More small break out sessions

Revisiting identity

Time for us to go out on our own